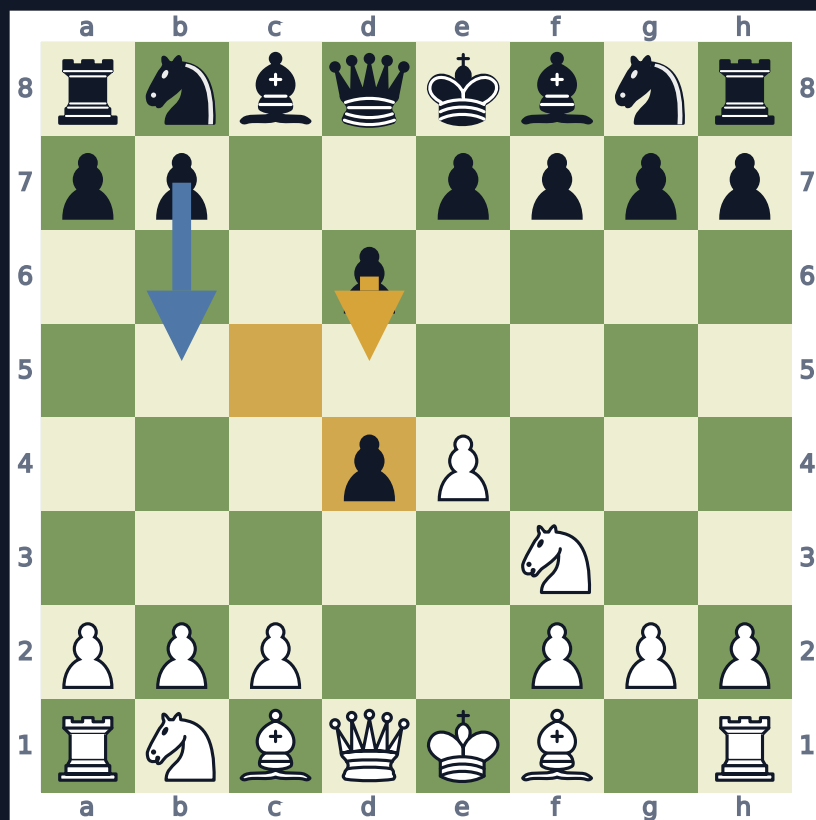


01

The Sicilian from First Principles

Why 1...c5 works, what Black accepts, and how the asymmetry changes every plan.

**THIS VOLUME****6**

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will stop treating the Sicilian as a list of names and begin reading it as a fight over d4, the c-file, development time, and unequal wings.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 001 | PAGE 4

Decode: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank*1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.*

LESSON 002 | PAGE 8

Play: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank*1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.*

LESSON 003 | PAGE 12

Decode: The half-open c-file bargain*A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.*

LESSON 004 | PAGE 16

Play: The half-open c-file bargain*A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.*

LESSON 005 | PAGE 20

Decode: Development before decoration*In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.*

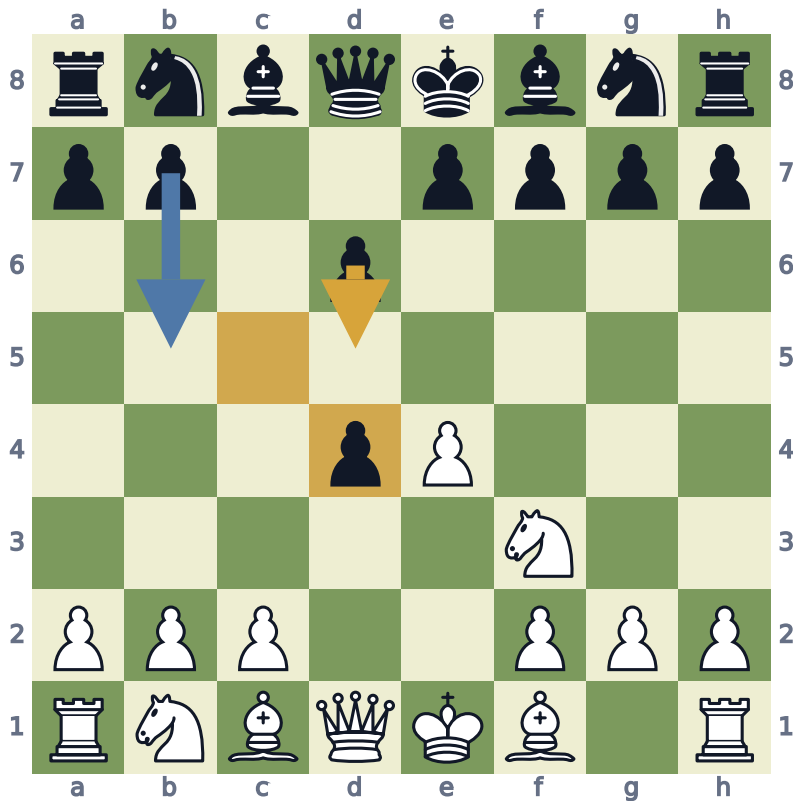
LESSON 006 | PAGE 24

Play: Development before decoration*In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will stop treating the Sicilian as a list of names and begin reading it as a fight over d4, the c-file, development time, and unequal wings.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

DECISION RULE

After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active.

MEMORY RULE | 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active.

FAILURE MODE

Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

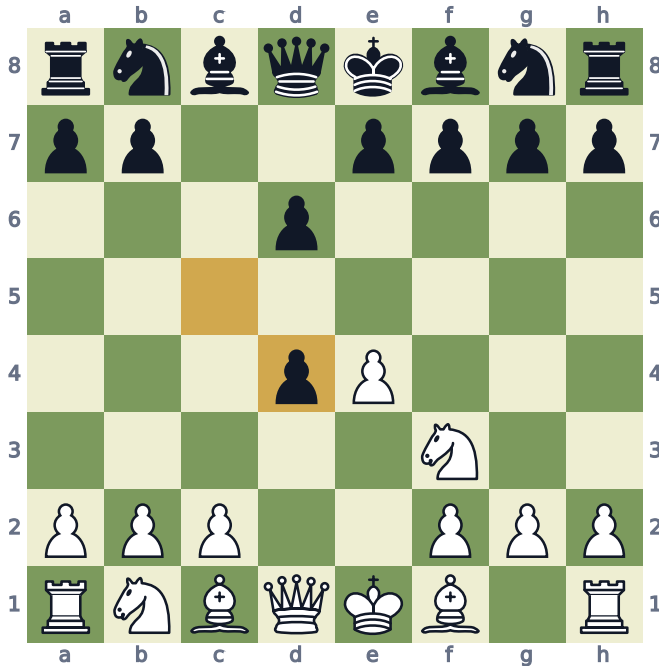
RULE | 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c5: Black challenges d4 from the flank and creates the asymmetry that defines the Sicilian.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d4: White builds the Open Sicilian center and offers the d-pawn for rapid development.
- cxd4: Black releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? White's resistance is: White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active. The line fails as a template when: Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

STORE THIS | 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances. 2. Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood. 3. White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active. 4. After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? 5. Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 6 plies from memory, then replay: 1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

DECISION RULE

After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active.

MEMORY RULE | 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active.

FAILURE MODE

Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d4: White builds the Open Sicilian center and offers the d-pawn for rapid development.
- cxd4: Black releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? White's resistance is: White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active. The line fails as a template when: Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

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ANSWER KEY

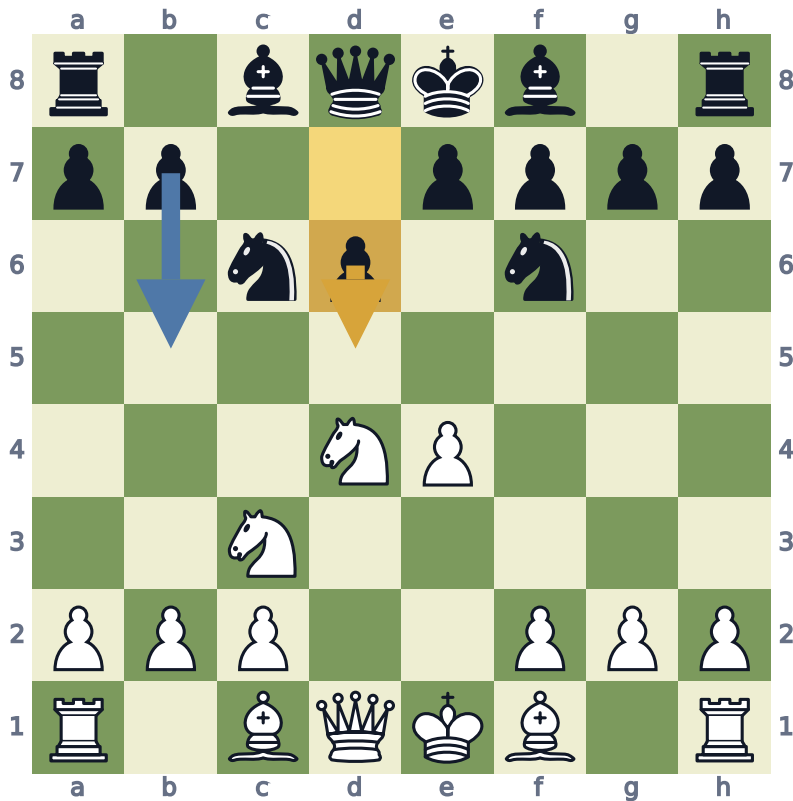
1. Black does not mirror 1.e4. The c-pawn challenges d4 while preserving the e-pawn, creating an unbalanced center and genuine winning chances. 2. Finish development without surrendering d5, use the half-open c-file, and choose ...e6 or ...e5 only when its square concessions are understood. 3. White uses the lead in space and development to build pressure before Black's queenside assets become active. 4. After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway? 5. Playing thematic pawn moves automatically while the king and queenside pieces remain undeveloped.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 8 plies from memory, then replay: 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The half-open c-file bargain

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

DECISION RULE

Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares.

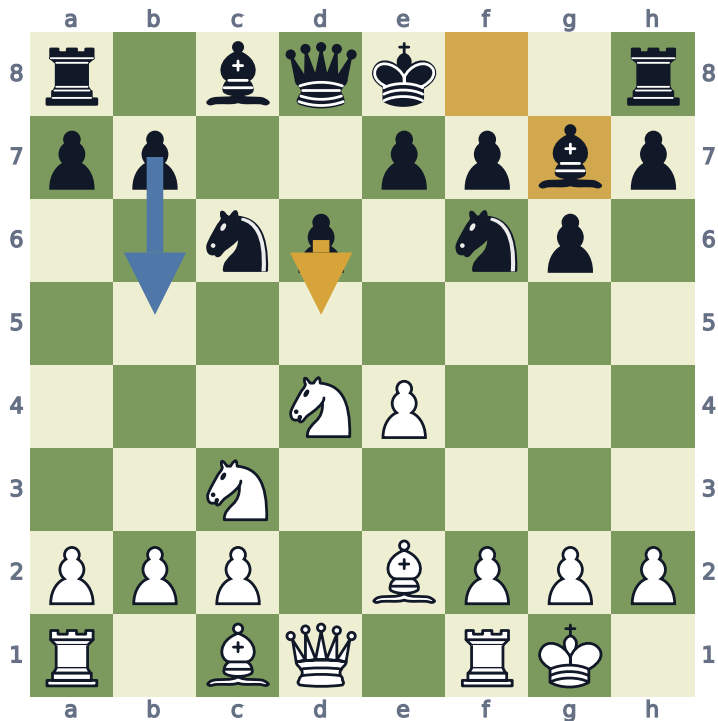
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete.

MEMORY RULE | A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete.

FAILURE MODE

Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

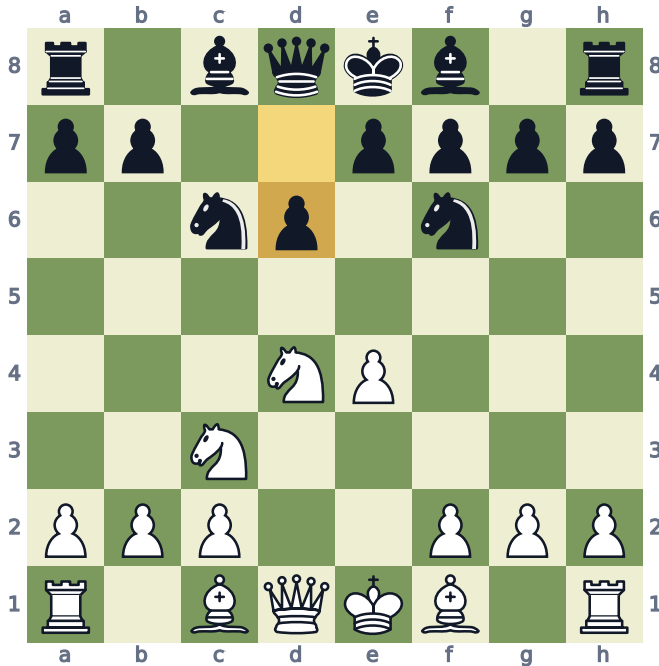
RULE | A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6 6. Be2 g6 7. O-O Bg7



- d4: White builds the Open Sicilian center and offers the d-pawn for rapid development.
- cxd4: Black releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? White's resistance is: White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete. The line fails as a template when: Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

STORE THIS | A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

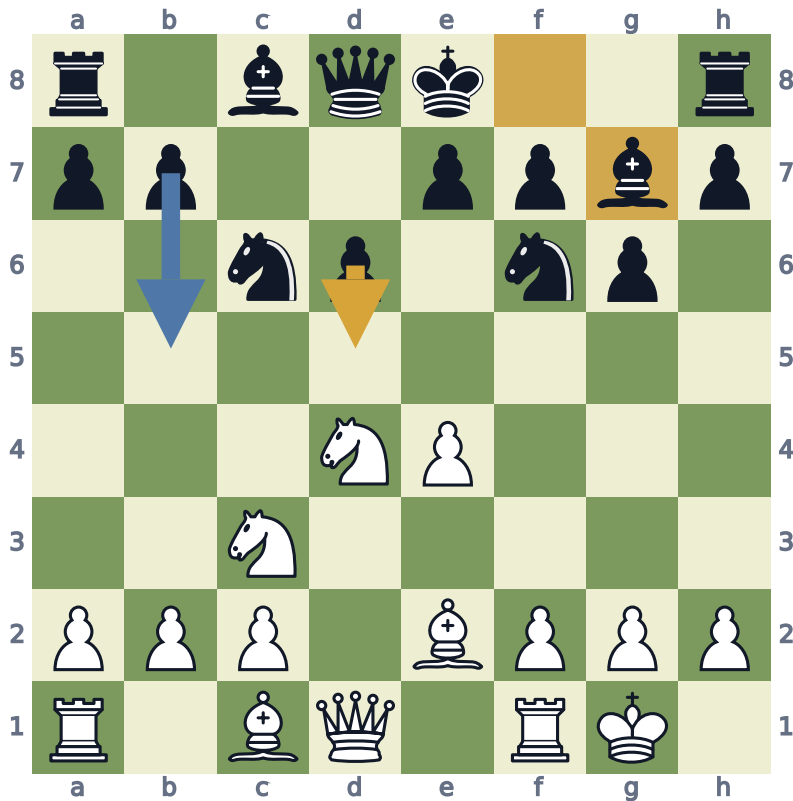
1. The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside. 2. Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares. 3. White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete. 4. Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? 5. Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The half-open c-file bargain



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

DECISION RULE

Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares.

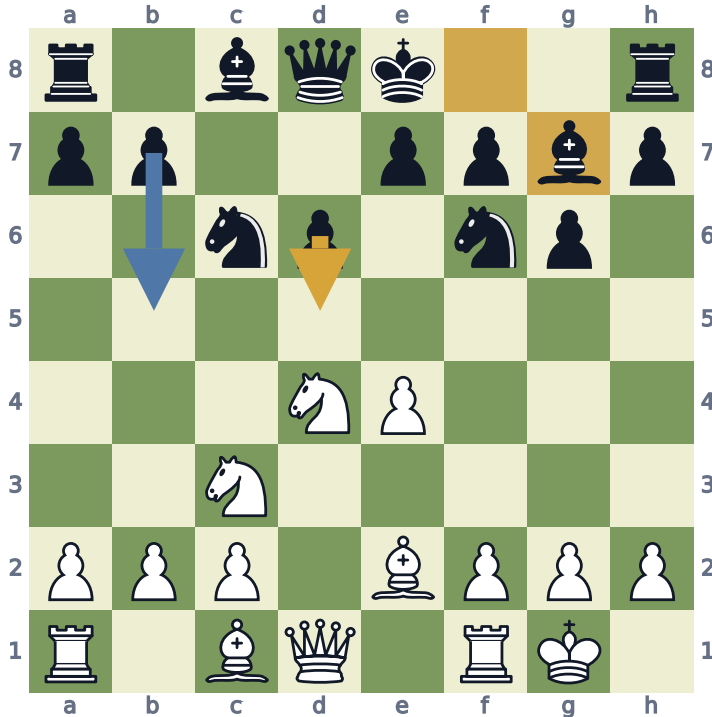
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete.

MEMORY RULE | A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete.

FAILURE MODE

Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

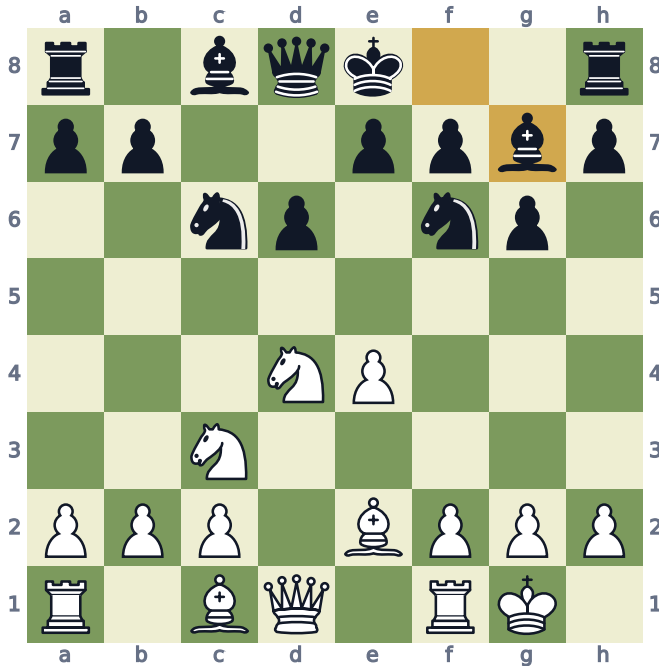
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6 6. Be2 g6 7. O-O Bg7



- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? White's resistance is: White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete. The line fails as a template when: Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

STORE THIS | A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

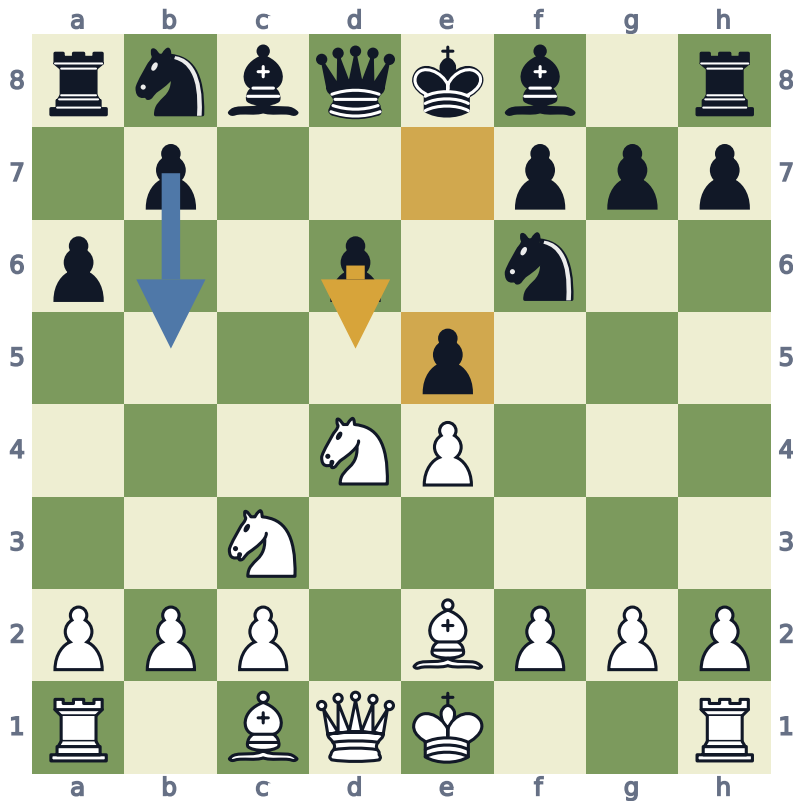
1. The exchange on d4 gives White a central pawn majority but gives Black a half-open c-file and targets on c2 and the queenside. 2. Coordinate queen and rook on the c-file, pressure c2, and make White spend time guarding entry squares. 3. White seeks central expansion or a kingside initiative before c-file pressure becomes concrete. 4. Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first? 5. Confusing possession of a half-open file with control of its entry squares.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nc3 d6 6. Be2 g6 7. O-O Bg7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Development before decoration



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

DECISION RULE

Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Develop, castle, and only then decide whether queenside expansion or central action is justified.

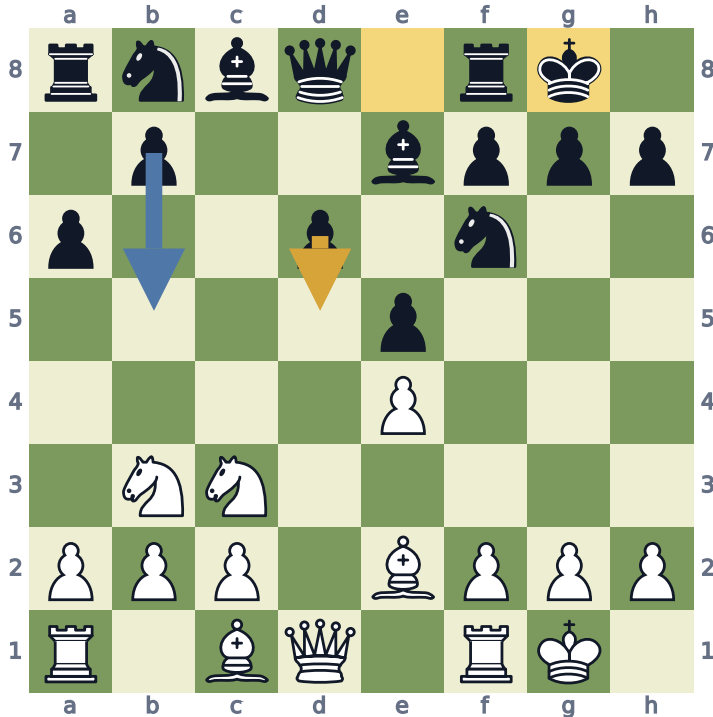
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed.

MEMORY RULE | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Develop, castle, and only then decide whether queenside expansion or central action is justified.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed.

FAILURE MODE

Collecting thematic moves such as ...a6, ...b5, and ...Qc7 without checking tactical readiness.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

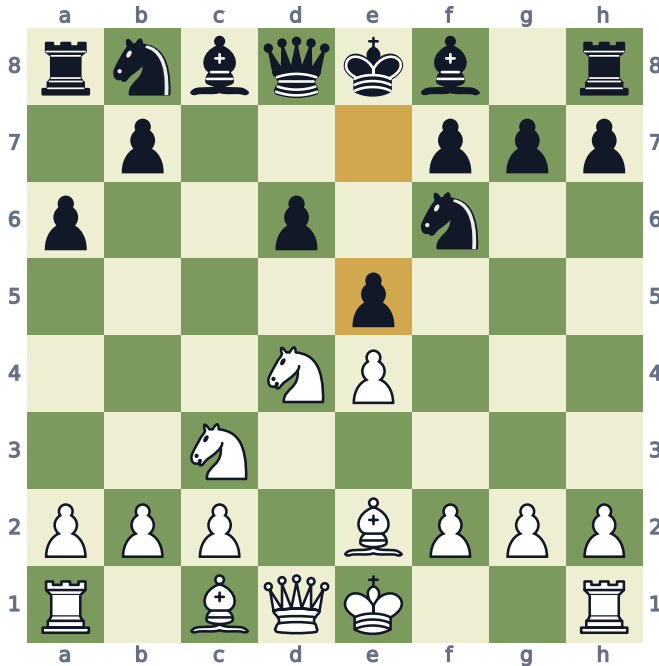
RULE | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation? White's resistance is: White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed. The line fails as a template when: Collecting thematic moves such as ...a6, ...b5, and ...Qc7 without checking tactical readiness.

STORE THIS | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

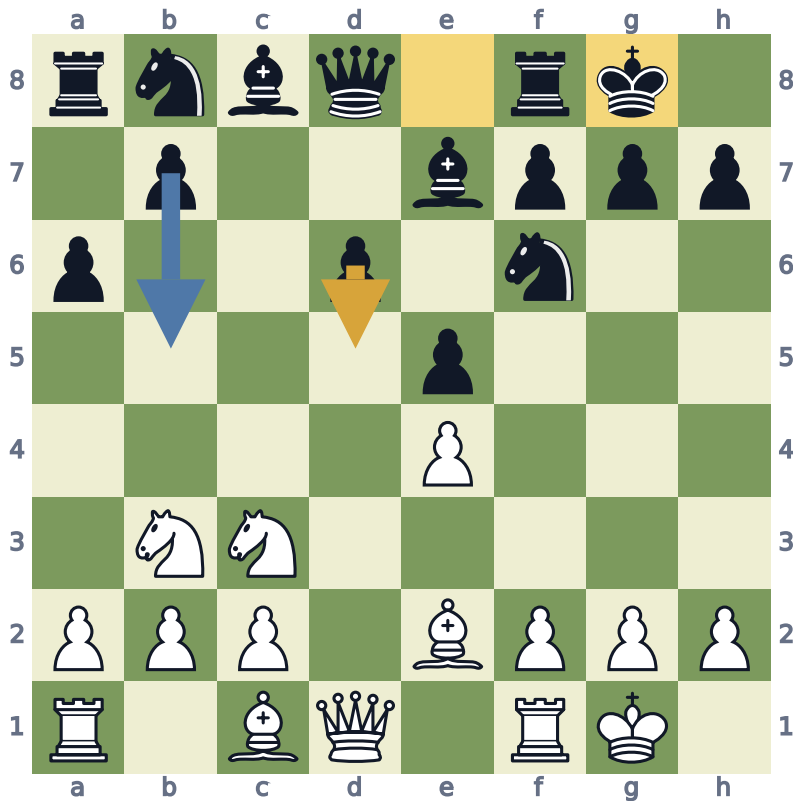
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Development before decoration



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

DECISION RULE

Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Develop, castle, and only then decide whether queenside expansion or central action is justified.

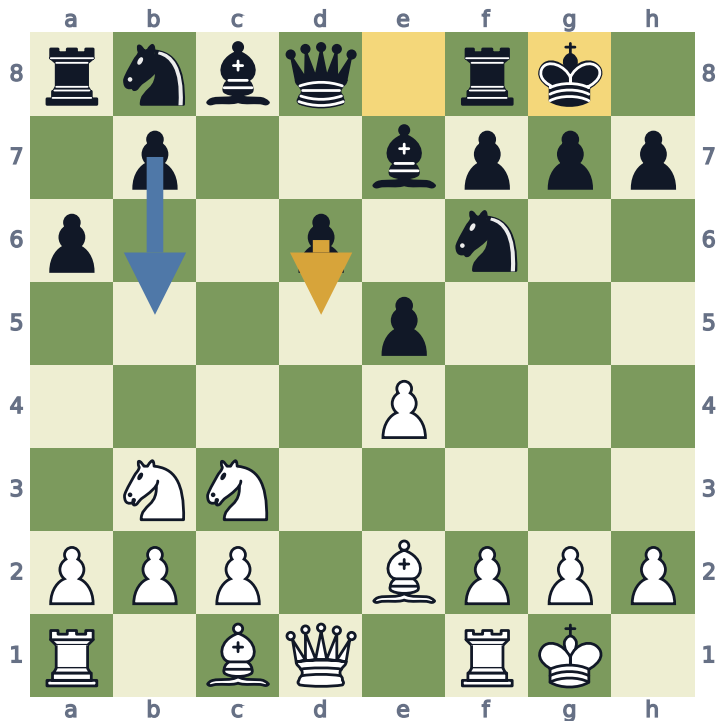
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed.

MEMORY RULE | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Develop, castle, and only then decide whether queenside expansion or central action is justified.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed.

FAILURE MODE

Collecting thematic moves such as ...a6, ...b5, and ...Qc7 without checking tactical readiness.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

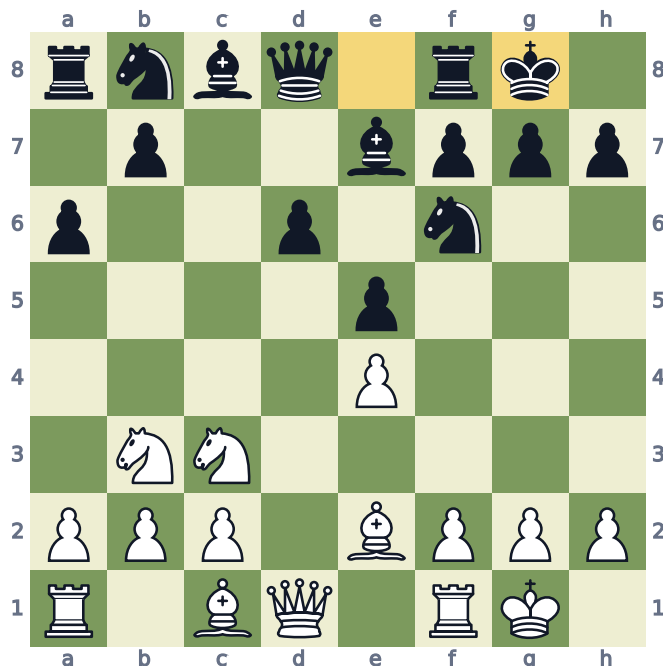
RULE | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Nb3: White reroutes a knight to b3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation? White's resistance is: White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed. The line fails as a template when: Collecting thematic moves such as ...a6, ...b5, and ...Qc7 without checking tactical readiness.

STORE THIS | In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Najdorf flexibility is valuable only after Black survives the development race; ...a6 is preparation, not permission to drift. 2. Develop, castle, and only then decide whether queenside expansion or central action is justified. 3. White tries to exploit every slow move with f4, Be3, or a central break while Black's king is still exposed. 4. Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation? 5. Collecting thematic moves such as ...a6, ...b5, and ...Qc7 without checking tactical readiness.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 001 Decode: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank

Prompt: After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway?

Recall: 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

LESSON 002 Play: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank

Prompt: After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway?

Recall: 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

LESSON 003 Decode: The half-open c-file bargain

Prompt: Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first?

Recall: A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

LESSON 004 Play: The half-open c-file bargain

Prompt: Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first?

Recall: A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

LESSON 005 Decode: Development before decoration

Prompt: Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation?

Recall: In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

LESSON 006 Play: Development before decoration

Prompt: Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation?

Recall: In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Why Black attacks d4 from the flank

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3

Decision: After the c-pawn exchange, which central square needs protection and which file became Black's long-term highway?

Memory: 1...c5 buys asymmetry; Black must pay for it with accurate development.

CARD 2

The half-open c-file bargain

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6 6. Be2 g6 7. O-O Bg7

Decision: Is the c-file currently an attacking line, or must development and a pawn break open access first?

Memory: A file matters only when pieces can enter it with tempo.

CARD 3

Development before decoration

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O

Decision: Can Black complete one useful developing move before starting the wing operation?

Memory: In the Sicilian, a slow move is safe only when it supports the next forcing event.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
001 Decode: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
002 Play: Why Black attacks d4 from the flank	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
003 Decode: The half-open c-file bargain	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
004 Play: The half-open c-file bargain	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
005 Decode: Development before decoration	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
006 Play: Development before decoration	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.